

SHAME AS A YARDSTICK FOR UNRESOLVED PROBLEMS; SEEMINGLY FAVORABLE CHILDHOOD CIRCUMSTANCES AS OBSTRUCTIVE AS HURTS

Greetings, my dearest friends. Blessings for all of you. Blessed be your efforts, your progress, and your life as a whole. May tonight's lecture again help you advance a step forward on your path. Perhaps, also, it may help some new friends to enter this path even though the contents of this lecture are primarily destined to reach those inner areas and levels of the personality which have already been uncovered or are about to be uncovered in this deep search of self-exploration. Therefore it may well be that for those of you who have not yet reached these deep levels the words may not have meaning, may sound repetitious, or may even be confusing. But I promise that once you have attained this inner level of recognition, these words will prove tremendously useful.

To all of my friends who are on the path, I want to say that every effort, regardless of how, at the moment, it may be fraught with discouragement or with a temporary feeling of hopelessness, must be crowned with success if you persevere. What may now appear as defeat will soon prove to be victory, prove to be absolutely necessary to have gone through at this period which seems difficult. Please remember, it is not difficult because of this work, but because of your unresolved problems that still exist. You cannot emphasize enough, as a constant reminder for yourself, that awareness is the key -- becoming aware of what is in you at the moment. Please, my friends, here or there, you are not yet sufficiently conscious of what really bothers you. If you will only realize this, you will know how to go in the right direction. You will not be in despair because you will see the missing link and thereby cease to be confused and lost. These words apply to many of my friends.

Tonight I should like to discuss two specific topics which will at first seem unrelated, but of course they are not, and we shall then try to establish their connection. The first topic is shame. This was discussed in the past in certain connections, such as the shame of the higher self or shame of certain shortcomings. Tonight I should like to discuss this topic from a very specific point of view.

When you pursue this path, you come to a point when you discover certain areas that you are ashamed of acknowledging even to yourself. What you may be ashamed of may be faults, but not always and not necessarily. You may be as ashamed of very legitimate needs as you are of faults, or of assets, for that matter. First, you are not even aware of the fact that such shames really exist. It takes a considerable amount of time and effort before you do become aware of certain facets within yourself of which you are deeply ashamed to face and which you cover with a pretense the reverse of your specific shame.

Slowly but surely, as the pathwork progresses in the right direction, you learn to face the shame only to yourself since you are not yet able to reveal it to others. When this phase is reached, a certain amount of self-deception has been eliminated. Whatever your personal particular shame and

consequent pretense may be varies. But whatever it is, when you come face to face with such an aspect, it takes a considerable amount of struggle and courage to admit what so far had been inadmissible. When the struggle has been overcome, a significant amount of inner freedom and ease has been reached. It is important to remember that such a victory rarely occurs in one ultimate struggle. The process may have to be repeated because the psyche is not ready to face all its pretenses at once. The degree of shedding the pretense to oneself, and facing that which was regarded as too shameful to admit, results in the concomitant degree of emotional ease and comfort. He who has reached the point of such self-admission can exactly pinpoint his shame, his pretense, his deception. He has indeed reached a major step in self-realization. Needless to say, he is way ahead, compared to the person who is as yet unaware of his shame and pretense and may therefore believe he has nothing to hide.

But then there is a further step. In this further step, you will find a wonderful way to measure your liberation. The degree of ease and emotional comfort with which you can discuss your shame with your helper indicates your inner freedom. But this important mark on the path is often overlooked because certain self-admissions are suspended and gradually forgotten as to their actual significance. While these admissions may have been made at one time, the pretense nevertheless continues to present itself to the outer world, as well as partly to the self, because the partial admission is not fully explored.

I should like to give specific advice in this respect. First of all, keep your attention poised in this direction. The first stage on this particular road within the path is becoming aware of what you have so far hidden from yourself. When this is done to some degree, ask yourself if you have utilized such findings or whether you have allowed them to become hazy again. True liberation cannot come in such half measures. Making the conscious recognition again only half-conscious is due to the specific reason, my friends, that you may not yet be ready and free enough to express to another person -- your helper -- this very shame that you have finally admitted to yourself. And because you cannot force yourself to it, you again becloud it. It becomes foggy again. It would be so much better and so vastly constructive for you to admit to yourself, "I cannot yet bring myself to reveal and discuss this or that aspect of my personality." Do not force yourself because if it is too forced, your anxiety and suffering will be such a strong countermeasure that the benefit may be lost. In such forceful measures, you cannot help but present it in a slightly distorted, untruthful, colored way. Hence, the gain is questionable. This would make you feel guilty and in turn breed new problems in the relationship between yourself and your helper. This is more harmful than the free admission, "I am not ready to reveal myself." In this admission, you are honest. You do not use too much force. You do not breed guilt and therefore resentment. And you gauge your inner stand. This is infinitely better than a dutiful and harried self-discipline of doing something that you are not ready for.

Ascertain in your daily review, "This or that factor brings me embarrassment. I feel too uncomfortable to discuss it." Come to terms with this factor, instead of having the frequent attitude of being unwilling to face this restraint and therefore not facing the significance of this lack of freedom. Thereby you overlook what is so important to see -- where do you stand, how far have you gotten, what remains to be accomplished toward this freedom from shame and pretense? Come to terms with this restraint and inhibition, and say to yourself that perhaps in a week, in a month, in a year, you may get to this point. But in the meantime, observe yourself in this respect; and perhaps, little by little, by dribs and drabs, without forceful discipline, you will reveal more than you intended.

At the beginning, you will be uncomfortable and anxious, embarrassed and inhibited, but each time it becomes easier. Suddenly you will see that your entire shame was an illusion as you gain inner comfort while freely expressing that which seemed so shameful. That is your yardstick of liberation.

I advise all of you to think about this specific part of the path. Are you aware of what you are ashamed? If you are not, you still have to find it. If you are, to what degree do you fully tackle this issue? Take it in your self-confrontation, all by yourself, and probe deeper, bringing out the issue of shame. Do not try to find immediate reasons and answers, explanations and justifications. Simply admit that this or that aspect causes you shame. Write down in exact and precise terms what it is and why you feel you need to be ashamed. The usual answer is always the fear of appearing less in the eyes of others, being less loveable and respectable, fearing belittlement and humiliation. But this general fact has to be specifically found and acknowledged as it applies to you. When this is done, confront yourself as to what degree you are able to discuss it. Observe your inner freedom of doing so if you succeed, perhaps only in degrees at this time. Maintain the awareness of this issue. Do not force revelation unduly (some force may be necessary at the beginning), but if you decide to wait, do not forget the issue. And continue in the meantime to observe daily reactions in respect to this issue. For you may be sure that your deep-rooted unresolved problem stands in direct relationship to your shame and inhibition and daily disharmonies. Problems directly or indirectly play into this facet. They need to be observed and recognized in this connection.

Each private session may give you an opportunity to open this particular door a little further. Each time, you will find it easier to discuss that which was formerly inadmissible. After each session, take notice of your reactions -- how far have you gone as compared with previous occasions in revealing yourself and how much do you still falsify and present a different front, be it ever so subtle? Perhaps a good way to make a beginning may be to discuss with your helper that you still have such restraints and are as yet unwilling or unable to give them up. You may thus touch upon the general area of your shame without as yet going into detail. This may prepare the way and create the proper climate. It goes without saying that the "inadmissible" applies much less to certain facts in your past life that you do not wish to be known and much more to an emotional pretense, a falsification of personality. The latter is infinitely more important and more damaging.

You cannot begin to know how important this approach is for your progress and your inner health. I also advise those of my friends here who are helpers to others to be aware of this factor, not only in themselves, of course, but also as an issue in those whom they are helping. They should remember that to the degree that they are still unfree in this respect, to that degree they cannot expect this freedom and self-revelation from those whom they help. It is so important to remember not to use a whip on yourself by forcing and rejecting yourself in self-condemnation if you do not succeed, but to quietly observe yourself where you stand in this particular respect.

If anyone claims that there is no area within himself which he cannot freely discuss in emotional comfort, I say he has not even found it yet. He has not yet even seen to what degree he still lives in inhibition and self-deception. If you discover that you are not yet as far as you have thought because of such restraint, this should not make you uneasy, for if you go about it in the way I advised, accepting your present stand and working on it in a relaxed and self-accepting way, there need be no compulsion, no guilt, no impatience with yourself -- only acknowledgment.

The second topic I wish to discuss is something we have not really gone into before except in a fleeting way on various occasions. For a long time in this work on understanding and resolving images, misconceptions, distorted unhealthy attitudes, in short, everything breeding problems in your life, we concentrated on unhappy, painful childhood events and conditions. We found that they were responsible for creating psychic conditions damaging to your self-unfoldment. Hurts and frustrations in childhood have been recognized as the cause for bringing out deeply imbedded problems in the personality. Now I would like to shed light on the exact opposite. Apparently favorable and positive factors in childhood can be equally responsible for inner distortions.

Offhand, this may appear quite impossible for it seems so much the opposite of what is currently believed. But let us look a little closer at this subject. You may note that I said apparently favorable conditions. Man's evaluation of what is good or bad, constructive or destructive, right or wrong, is often tied in with what is momentarily pleasurable or unpleasurable, on the one hand; and on the other hand, with what conforms to temporary, superimposed values. On the one side, he may deem something as constructive and good because it is pleasant for him. On the other side, he may deem the unpleasant as right because it conforms to those superimposed, arbitrary value systems that mankind often follows.

I sometimes mentioned the difference between eternal values as opposed to temporary values. Temporary values may remain the same throughout centuries and still be considered temporary by their nature of abiding with noneternal valuations. They come into being because of the needs of a particular civilization and mankind's limitation in grasping eternal values. These needs are dictated by the conditions which the specific society lives in. Social, economic, political factors play a role; geography also does, as well as the type of spirit predominantly incarnated in this society. For example, values differ drastically in a patriarchy from those in a matriarchy. They differ in a monarchy and in a democracy. And many, many other factors contribute to make up the value system of a society. Due to man's inclination and laziness, he blindly follows what is established and retains values for long after their temporary usefulness in the specific conditions for which these values were created. Man's self-alienation, his lack of independent thinking, makes him cling to what is handed to him without thinking about it. This is why it is so important on this path to question everything you accept or reject and find your own reasons for doing so. This is the only way eternal values can be found. Each case, each incident, each issue must be tested and probed, questioned and sincerely answered from the depth of one's own convictions. They must be deeply examined. Then and then only can the divine attributes be truly found, not because everyone says so, because society agrees, but because one finds it so oneself. These divine attributes and eternal values are unchangeable in themselves but constantly change in their application. It is the exact opposite with temporary values. Eternal values often disregard the temporary ones, and often seem to be the same although their climate is a very different one even if the outer act may be similar. Love, truth, wisdom, courage, what is good and constructive in the long run and therefore for all concerned, are the sole considerations of eternal values. To find these considerations cannot be done by blind acceptance. Eternal values may be pleasurable and go against the temporary value system. And they may be unpleasurable at the moment and go hand in hand with the temporary value system. However, if man acts accordingly, but in order to obey the latter while being unaware of the former, he will not be in peace with himself. In any personal choice and decision, in important and unimportant issues, in actions, and in emotional direction and attitudes, he is dependent on whether or not the decision derives from the one or the other value system. There is no formula. Coming

into selfhood means not by claiming but rather by examining, feeling, and living, "This is the way it is."

The value system regarding the treatment of children has undergone a drastic change in your society in recent times. Until a relatively short time ago, restriction and severity was the generally accepted "right way." Hence, man's unresolved problems entered into these rules, and he acted out his pent-up hostility under the pretext of following the existing value system. In recent times, the accepted rules are permissiveness, lack of discipline, indulgence. This does not mean that the parent's pent-up hostility does not communicate itself to the child. But simultaneously, these new values cause the parents to feel doubly guilty for them. As a result, indulgence and permissiveness are then executed apparently so as to annul the hostility and so as to conform to the rules. This may outwardly appear as love. Real love may certainly exist as well. But to the degree that it is diluted by guilt for the hostility which is not recognized as well as by the guilt for not conforming to present values, to that degree the pleasurable indulgence and permissiveness will create as many problematic conditions in the child's psyche as hurts and frustrations do.

If parents are not exclusively motivated by love which is sufficiently far-sighted to restrict, if necessary, their guilt; inner confusions and the inability to cope with the problems that a child represents will create an inner disturbance. In order to atone for the common human failings such as impatience, irritation, etc., the child may be overindulged and pampered. The child may experience this as something favorable and pleasurable at the moment, but the negative effect remains. Again, it is not the act nor its consequence alone which create the damage, but the guilt, confusion, and conflict in the parents. The identical act may in one case derive from such overindulgence, and in the other from a clear, unconfused psyche. The effect on the child depends on whether it is the one or the other. Moreover, it is the child's inborn health or its lack which determines whether it is affected by the parent's unresolved problems. This applies not only to inflicted hurt, but equally on pleasurable overindulgence. It, too, will have no adverse effect on the child's psyche if no corresponding problems exist.

Now let us examine the specific effects of apparently pleasurable circumstances such as permissiveness, pampering, indulgence. The psyche gets accustomed to it, and when life later prohibits similar indulgence, the personality is still driven to duplicate the pleasurable state it once enjoyed. He seeks that which he experienced as love during childhood over and over again, but he cannot find it because other people, not bound in guilt, will have no need to atone and therefore no need to extend such treatment. The inability to repeat what he once had causes hurt, anger, and hostility. The insistence upon having the protection and real as well as pseudolove enjoyed in childhood are connected with and dependent upon the hurts and frustrations suffered. In other words, just as the parent may overindulge as a substitute for inner irritation and rejection of the problems a child brings, so may the child use the compulsive need for overindulgence as a substitute for the negative currents in the parents that he unconsciously feels -- and sometimes even outwardly experiences in a more or less direct way.

It is time, my dear friends, that we now begin to examine those aspects in your childhood which you experienced in a pleasurable way. It took considerable insight into yourself to uncover the hurts and frustration. A child is apt to take for granted as permanent that which exists in his life. If he is hurt, he may suffer from it, rebel against it, but it is nevertheless an accepted fact the child cannot evaluate in objective terms. It is a general climate. It is the same with those pleasurable

aspects. The child may enjoy them, but is no more aware of them than he may be of the hurts. Both are aspects of the general climate the child does not question in spite of enjoyment or pain. Therefore it needs considerable probing and examination to become specifically aware of these elements. The experience of the past work pertaining to the hurts and pain during childhood will now prove useful in that it will be easier to become aware of the opposite. But it does require attention, concentration, and self-examination. When you make some headway in this respect, you will discover how important it is to understand the totality of your present personality, how much it plays a role in your mental and emotional makeup. You will see how you strive to reproduce not only that which you did not have, but also that which you did have. In other words, man not only attempts to correct his past lacks, but also perpetuate that which he has had. And this angle is vastly overlooked in the exploration of human psychic disturbance.

These words are once more a proof that the conduct is not the criterion for the right and constructive act, but rather it is the inner conditions, motivations, and the underlying unification of the psyche. In one instance, it may be right to indulge and be permissive, in another to restrict and even punish. He who wants outer regulations to abide by in order to know which alternative to use on what occasion must be lost and confused because his actions will prove unsuccessful. But he who knows himself, who understands his inner problems, will also know what conduct to choose even long before the inner problems are completely resolved. He is then in a position to act and to be in accord with eternal values. This applies to the treatment of children as well as to any other human relationship or human situation. Wherever such confusion exists, it should be a sign that knowledge about the self is missing.

So, my friends, examine this new angle. Be on the lookout for the following. To the degree that you felt unloved, to that degree guilt-love will have damaged you. Both play a role only because psychic unrealities were already in you before you were born into this life. You will see that a great deal of anger and resentment exist not only for that which you did not have, but also for what you did have and wish to continue having.

Offhand, you may wonder what the connection between tonight's two topics is and why I have chosen to discuss them in one lecture. But once both subjects are understood on a more profound level, the connection is quite evident. It may be constructive, my friends, if I now let you participate. Can any of you see a connecting link? Who has an idea?

QUESTION: I think it would be a very shameful feeling not to be grateful for what was meant to be good if you didn't feel it was good or if you were given something you did not want.

ANSWER: This may be quite true, but actually what I was referring to was not that you were given something which you did not want, but something which you very much enjoyed, but which you were perhaps just as unaware of as of a hurt. I did not mean something not wanted.

QUESTION: If a girl loves her father very much and asks for the same love in a man, later the child may experience the love for the father almost in a sexual way. Then she wants the same love from the man but can't get it; then she may have a shame in this respect.

ANSWER: This is a good example.

QUESTION: I have a feeling if parents are neglectful in some ways and, through their guilt, are particularly indulgent toward a child when it is sick, the child will want the sickness in order to get the love. Later in life, when the person is sick, he will be disappointed and hurt when the love is not forthcoming. At the same time, he will be ashamed for using sickness to get love.

ANSWER: This is a good example, too.

QUESTION: You may also be ashamed when you are told you are loved as a child, but don't feel it.

ANSWER: Yes.

QUESTION: Shame is always connected with guilt, isn't it?

ANSWER: Not always. They may go together, but it is also possible to feel shame without guilt, and guilt without shame.

QUESTION: When the child receives an allowance and he feels guilty for keeping it while not actually deserving it, he later feels shame for receiving a salary.

ANSWER: Such a case requires further understanding why this guilt and shame for having received an allowance exists.

QUESTION: I know a case of an adopted child. Here the parents gave the child too much leeway, continuously admiring him. This was probably due to lack of real love. Later when the child was about eighteen years old, he became even more demanding, and the parents could not gratify these demands. I think the child was ashamed of not having his real parents.

ANSWER: This may be so. These are partly good examples. Such participation will help you to assimilate better. Let me now show you, in principle, the connection between the damage of pleasurable childhood experience and shame.

If a human being wants to reproduce pleasurable conditions in later life, it indicates the desire to remain a child, on the receiving line. It indicates greed and lack of self-responsibility. This may be inadmissible for some, particularly those who pride themselves on being mature and adult. Most people wish to be so regarded while desiring as well the advantages of adulthood. The desire to be a child, as well as anger for the frustration, must create a shame. This tendency often contradicts completely the ideal which is superimposed, the front which is presented to the world and to the conscious self. As you know, the idealized self-image denies all limitations. It pretends possessing all which the personality feels lacking. The pretense of the idealized self is the crux of the matter. The pretense not only hides what the child felt to be missing in its life, but also what it has had and wants to continue having. If you examine your idealized self, this double pretense must be found. The opposite of this pretense lies underneath. To reveal it seems like a dreadful admission. You cannot discover the shame if you do not envisage the exact opposite of your pretense. The consideration of the exact opposite of the idealized self-image should now be taken into this work -- by all of you. This must be the shame, which also connects with certain pleasurable circumstances in childhood. Perhaps you were praised for certain real or partly real qualities you yourself suspect

as not possessing in the measure that your parents claimed for you. Or maybe you only think these qualities are absent because they are still too diluted with your various self-doubts and distortions in various ways. We discussed the idealized self-image at length. Now let us look at its opposite. Let us find its specific significance and therefore what would be, in essence, its opposite. It is this opposite which creates the deep shame and which is also connected with both pleasant and unpleasant childhood conditions.

If you really study this lecture and work through it, I promise that your liberation and progress will be considerable. This will indeed be the crux of that which makes you suffer, of that which alienates you from life and yourself, of that which makes you puzzled and confused. With this, you have a direct key, my dearest friends, each and every one of you, each in a different way. For some friends, this may be premature. Many other aspects have to be explored before they can come to this. It is not always a matter of the length of time, though. Occasionally someone who is on the path a shorter period of time may discover certain aspects another individual can come across only after more extended work. This all depends on the type of character and psychic conditions as well as on the attitude to one's problems. Wherever you stand now, take this into consideration. This coming working year will indeed prove a most important and crucial one if this lecture is halfway understood and assimilated.

Is there any question pertaining to this lecture?

QUESTION: If a child was a favorite and in a privileged position, is it that later he may unconsciously claim a similar privileged position -- that he may want special consideration?

ANSWER: Yes, indeed. This may be absolutely unconscious, for it may be diametrically opposed to one's idealized self. If the child held this special position because it was a good child, this goodness is then an integral part of the idealized self. Goodness means also self-sacrifice and unselfishness. Yet this contradicts the claim for special treatment. In this inner confusion, so much is repressed, and the more this is the case, the less clarification can be gotten. When all these various inner demands and attitudes are out in the open, the clarification, liberation, and relief must be great. I tell you, my friend, you are on the way, you are almost there. With asking this question, and the light that flickered in now, you are almost there. You will then also understand your specific God image.

Love streams to each one of you. It is a vibrant force of reality. May all of you who make such valiant efforts in self-confrontation realize how meaningful and significant these efforts are. Continue, all of you! Life will thank you for it, but I do not mean this in the sense of a rewarding or punishing God. The cosmic forces with which you come into harmony by truthful self-examination respond according to law, while self-deception and lack of awareness cannot bring you into harmony with these cosmic forces. Be blessed, every one of you, so that your continuous efforts will be strengthened, so as to become freer and happier. Be in peace, be in God!

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